

KEY MOMENT

THE CANING OF MASSACHUSETTS SENATOR CHARLES SUMNER



THE SUMNER CANING, A PROVOCATIVE EXAMPLE OF SOUTHERN CHIVALRY

On May 19-20, 1856, Charles Sumner delivered a two-day speech in the Senate attacking slavery and its sexual abuses. Two days later, Congressman Preston Brooks of South Carolina, having read the text of the speech, was so enraged that he marched into the Senate and attacked Sumner at his desk, beating him unconscious with his cane, which shattered as a result of the violent blows. Brooks believed that Sumner's speech had slandered his uncle, Senator Andrew Butler.

This unprecedented attack on the Senate floor shocked Northerners, who considered it an assault on free speech. Republicans used the attack to create effective campaign rhetoric "proving" the threat to Northern liberties posed by Southern enslavers.

A climate of fear

That same evening, reports arrived that Lawrence, Kansas, the center of free-state settlers, had been sacked and burned by pro-slavery militia from Missouri. Stories circulated of murder, pillage, and rape, but in fact the only casualty was a Missouri raider, killed by a brick falling from a burning hotel. Confrontations over slavery in Kansas suddenly became part of a larger pattern of violence.